

The Madness at Arch Madness

This weekend, March 5th through 8th, UNI Men's basketball participated in the 2026 Missouri Valley Conference Arch Madness Tournament. The weekend started on Thursday, March 5, 2026, with the Panthers playing against the Evansville Purple Aces. The Aces were ranked 11th out of 11 teams in the conference, while UNI was ranked 6th. The game started slowly in terms of points. The first point of the game was scored by Will Hornseth of UNI during a free throw. At 15:43, Leon Bond III attempted a 23-foot 3-point shot but missed. Hornseth was able to rebound the ball and then make a layup for 2 points. This was amazing to watch. Another great play from the first half was at 12:52 when Ben Schwieger blocked a shot and rebounded the ball, which allowed Trey Campbell to pass the ball to Bond III for a diving layup. Again, this was amazing to watch. During the first half, UNI showed its elite defense by talking the shot clock for Evansville down to almost 0 multiple times. The Panthers also blocked several of the Ace's shots. At 1:43 left in the first Tristian Smith poked the ball free from the Aces and ran it over to deliver a powerful dunk for UNI. Unfortunately for the Panthers, the Aces would score a 3 point shot right as the half was ending, leaving UNI at 35 and Evansville at 36.

The second half started with Max Wiesbrod stealing the ball from Evansville and then making a diving layup to score 2 points putting the Panthers back on top. Where they would stay for the rest of the game, but not without it getting close. This half was incredibly fast paced, even faster than the first half. UNI made some great plays this half, starting with an amazing save by Smith. As Smith batted the ball to stay inbounds, Hornseth took the and dunked the ball into the net. This was powerful to say the least. Later in the half, Hornseth misses his second free throw but Smith is able to get the rebound and push to make a dunk for the Panthers. At one point UNI racked up 6 fouls in 6 minutes. But to make up for this influx of fouls, in the last minute Weisebrod gets 6 free throws and makes 5 of them. This was insane to witness because it felt like the game was just repeating the same few seconds over. In the end UNI stayed ahead of the Evansville Aces beating them 68-59. This meant that UNI would be playing the following day.

On March 6th, 2026, UNI faced off against Illinois State after winning against Evansville the previous night. Illinois State was ranked 3rd in the conference. This game was going to be a tough one. UNI had not beat Illinois state at all during the regular season. The last game on February 26 was very close with UNI only losing by 2 points. This game would not start off great due to a delayed start time. The previous game, UIC vs. Valpariso, went into double overtime. Tip off was set to 9:30 due to this. This was brutal, especially after starting the previous night's game at 8:30. The game started with UNI winning the tip off. Campbell then scored a 23-foot 3-point shot. This game really showed how great UNI's defense is. By the end of the game Illinois state had a field goal percent of 33% and their 3-point precantage wa 15%. There were many times where UNI blocked the ball from being scored. This game was close but also no at all. By the end of the first half, the Redbirds where still down and there had been no lead changes the whole half. Both the insane amount of blocks that UNI handed out and the several time UNI brought the shot clock down to seconds left, the Panther's defense was on fire. There was very few time where the Panthers let the Redbirds even attempt to score. UNI closed out the 1st by having Hornseth score 2-points with the assistance of RJ Taylor. The first half ended

with UNI at 35 and Illinois State at 27. The second half opened with a missed shot by the Redbird's Landon Wolf. UNI get the first points of the half when Bond III scored 2 with the assistance of Hornseth. Another common thing this game was fouls. By the end of the game UNI had accumulated 25 fouls. Illinois state only accumulated 15 fouls during the game. At the start of the half, UNI was 8 points ahead. This gap would only grow throughout the second half. Overall this game was hard but not really close at all. One thing a cheer member of Illinois State told me before the game was that UNI scared the Illinois State players. I think this game showed just how scared the Redbirds were. The final score was 74 to 52. This is a 22 point lead which is the largest lead UNI had all game.

On March 7th, 2026, at 5:30, UNI played against #2-ranked Bradley in the Semi-finals for Arch Madness. Going into this game UNI had beat Bradley once during the regular season. Another plus was that was the most recent faceoff against Bradley. The game started as all the previous ones in this tournament have with UNI winning the tip off. Another uni trend was scoring the first points which also happened this game when Hornseth scored 2-points. UNI then stayed ahead of Bradley until at 16:58 Bradley's Corey Thomas scored 2 points putting Bradley at 7 and UNI at 6. This lead for Bradley would not last long. At 16:42 Campbell scored 2 for UNI bringing them back in the lead. A majority of this game was back and forth scoring of points with UNI staying just ahead of Bradley. With 10 minutes left in the half UNI built up a solid lead by scoring 7 points in a row. The first half would end with Bradley's Thomas scoring 2 points. This brought the score to UNI 45 and Bradley 32. Uni has a field goal percentage of 71.4 during the first half while Bradley had a percentage of 48. The second half started with Smith making a 2-point hook shot. Smith at 17:36 got to take 2 free throw shots, both which he made. Smith then immediately after his free throws got fouled. The pattern for the 2nd half was UNI steal, UNI scores, Bradley scores, UNI scores, repeat. There were also a lot of substitutions for both teams though out the game. The last point of the game was scored by Bond III during a free throw. This brings the final score to 73-69, Panthers win. This win meant that UNI is the lowest seeded team to make it to the championship game at seed 6. They are also the second team to play all 4 days of the tournament. A main trend in this game was that Bradley put all their eggs in the 3-point basket while UNI went for scoring in the paint. UNI had 35 attempts inside the arc and 9 outside. Their field goal percentage was 66 with a 67% on 3-points. Bradley had 34 attempts inside the arc and 21 outside. Their field goal percentage was 43 with 3-points at 38%. With this game over, it is now time to see if UNI can do well on day 4.

UNI has made it to the Championship game for Arch Madness and they are playing against the 5th-ranked team, UIC. UNI had only beat UIC once during the regular season. UNI was also favored to win this game at a 65.5% chance of winning. This game had a different start than all the other games this weekend, UNI lost the jump ball. However, UNI did score the first points with Smith making a layup for 2-points. The Panthers quickly made a solid lead by scoring 8 times in 3 minutes. During this time, UIC was also scoring but not to the degree UNI was. Starting at 2:36, UNI and UIC went back and forth on scoring. It started with UIC's Elijah Crawford scoring 2 points. At 2:18, Bond III scored 2. Then at 2:00, UIC scored 3. 1:32 saw another Panther score, 3 points this time. At 1:09 UIC scores 2, followed by UNI scoring 2 at

0:49, then back to UIC scoring 2 at 0:33. The last point scored of the half was by UIC's Crawford during a free throw. After a hard half of keeping just ahead of UIC, the Panthers end at 48 and UIC at 41. The first points of the 2nd half were scored by UIC but was quickly followed by 3 points from Campbell. After a 3 minutes scoring drought for UNI, the Flames were catching up. This drought allowed for UIC to eventually become 2 points down. Thankfully UNI pulled back ahead by scoring 2 3-point shots back to back. UNI continued to pull further and further ahead of UIC moving forward. By the end of the game UIC was down 17 points. The last points for UNI was scored by Smith during a free throw. UIC scored the final points of the game. Was the clock at zero, UNI became the first team in Missouri Valley Conference history to play 4 games in a row during the tournament and win all of them. This also ended a 20 year drought of UNI not winning the championship game. During the game, whenever UNI scored the crowd went crazy. No matter how small it was. Unlike UIC, who after seeing the writing on the wall during the second half, almost stopped cheering. Another thing I noticed during the games was that UNI kept setting up things like dunks but missing them. This happened several times through out the game. While this was mostly for show, it did allow for UIC to score while UNI did not. Over all this game was historic and entertaining. There was really only one moment where it seemed like UNI would lose. What a great tournament. Looking forward UNI will get their placement for the Big Dance on March 15th.